



success MANTRA

Be positive and honest, plan long term and protect shareholders

role MODEL

Deepak Chopra, his first boss and now CEO of a competitor company

biggest STRUGGLE

Surviving in the US and buying food by doing odd jobs for a year

VINOD RAMNANI

52, MEDICAL DEVICE MANUFACTURER
CHAIRMAN AND MD, O C I
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1990 Rs 1 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 468 crore

SMART SENSOR

For Vinod Ramnani, 52, and the youngest of five children of an Indian Railways clerk, it has always been a tough but fruitful climb to success. What began as a struggle for subsistence in the US has now culminated into him presiding over Opto Circuits (India) Limited (oci), whose current turnover is over Rs 460 crore. Launched in 1990 in Bangalore, oci is engaged in the design, development, manufacture and marketing of medical electronic devices and healthcare products like pulse oximeters, digital thermometers and cholesterol monitors. What is gratifying is that he is able to provide them at least 30 per cent cheaper than established players. Today, oci does business in five continents and employs more than 1,000 people.

Who can imagine that this engineering graduate had been making a living out from persuading African-American women to buy expensive boots in Chicago in 1982? He then moved to Los

Angeles where he sold saris and fabric. "It was a meaningful experience in understanding human behaviour and improving marketing skills," reminisces Ramnani. It was here that he made his first and best acquaintances among doctors and other professionals, who later became his business associates.

It took Ramnani, then 27, two years to get a job mirroring his academic background. In 1987, he moved to Singapore to join his ex-boss and mentor Deepak Chopra, who now heads OSI Systems, oci's competitor. Three years later, with the help of a few friends, he started his own company. Within two years, owing to rising labour costs in Singapore, he came back to India and began oci. Today, an expanding manufacturing base here has made him optimistic. "With a never-say-die attitude, you can succeed in business anytime and anywhere," argues Ramnani. Few will disagree.

by Amarnath K. Menon